Week 9 Teacher Guide: The Altar Today: Living Sacrifice, Royal Priesthood

The Obedience of Faith, Week 9 of 12. Closes Unit III (Testing).

Companion to Week09-TheAltarToday.pptx.

Scripture from the NET Bible.

Aim: Answer "do Christians offer sacrifices?": the atonement is finished once for all, and precisely *because* it is finished, the worshiper now goes on the altar alive, body and mind.

What this week must accomplish (and nothing more): the class leaves holding one hinge and one convergence. The hinge: *sacrifice didn't end; it changed material.* The convergence: *Romans 12:1–2 and Hebrews 5:14 are the same paragraph*: the living sacrifice and the trained discernment the whole course has pursued turn out to be one thing. If the class sees that the daily chapter they read is not preparation for worship but *is* the offering, the week has done its deepest work. This is the intellectual peak of the course; everything from Week 1 converges here.

Where this sits in the arc: Week 9 closes the sacrifice thread opened in Week 2 (the four layers, Moriah) and the testing thread of Unit III, and it ties them to the discernment thread of Unit II. It is the last "discipleship spine" week before the course turns to church order (Weeks 10–11) and commission (12). The reading assignment already points into the contested Unit IV, so use the close to give a gentle heads-up.

Two guardrails to keep lit: one old, one new:

1. *The grace guardrail* (Weeks 4, 7, 8): this is a "sacrifice" week, so the works-righteousness reflex is live. The banner "mercy first, altar second" is on slide 5; the once-for-all guard is the *entire* first segment. Keep both loud.
2. *The atonement guardrail* (new this week, and the more important one): a lesson calling believers to "offer sacrifices" can be misheard as adding to the cross, as if Christ's work were incomplete and we finish it. Slide 2 exists precisely to slam that door before the turn. Christ's atoning sacrifice is *finished, once for all, unrepeatable.* Nothing we offer atones for anything. Our sacrifices are *response and worship*, never *propitiation*. Say this explicitly; a Catholic-background or a scrupulous member will especially need to hear it.

Presentation

Segment 1: First, the Guard (0:00–8:00 · Slide 2)

Open with the question and let it hang: "Do Christians offer sacrifices? Most of us would say no; that ended at the cross. Half of that is exactly right, and we start with that half."

Hebrews 10:10, 14 (first click). "Made holy through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ *once for all*… by one offering he has perfected *for all time* those who are made holy." The Greek *ephapax* (once for all, never to be repeated) is one of Hebrews' hinge words. Read both verses; the second ("perfected for all time") forecloses the idea that anything remains to be added.

Once for all (second click). State it as bluntly as the text does: the atoning work is complete, finished, unrepeatable. No altar you build, no sacrifice you offer, no discipline you practice adds a single thing to it. It cannot be improved; it can only be received. This is the guard that keeps the whole week from collapsing into works-salvation, the very error Week 4 inoculated against.

The contrast (third click, Heb 10:11–12). Hebrews makes the point with a picture: the old priests *stood* (*daily*) offering the same sacrifices that could never actually take sins away; Christ offered *one* sacrifice and *sat down*. A seated priest is a startling image: no Levite ever sat in the sanctuary, because the work was never finished. Christ sat because his was. The posture *is* the doctrine.

Hold the guard the whole hour (fourth click). Say it plainly: nothing in the rest of this lesson reopens the cross. Never let anyone (including yourself) put you back under a system of earning. *And yet*, as the rest of the hour will resolve, the New Testament keeps using sacrifice language *for us*. Romans 12, 1 Peter 2, Hebrews 13. If the atonement is finished, why does Scripture still call us to offer sacrifices? Not a contradiction. A change of material.

Transition: "Here is the turn."

Segment 2: The Turn: Sacrifice Changed Material (8:00–20:00 · Slide 3)

The diagram (first click). Walk it left to right. OLD: the lamb dies *instead of* the worshiper: a substitute goes on the altar in his place. CENTER: at the cross, the true Substitute dies, once for all (last week's territory). NOW: the worshiper himself goes on the altar, and notice the final altar has *no fire*. That's deliberate and it's the whole point: this sacrifice is meant to stay *alive*. Every prior sacrifice was consumed; this one breathes.

The hinge sentence (second click). "Sacrifice didn't end. It changed material." Pause on both sides of it. Under the old covenant a substitute died in your place; you brought the lamb and it went up instead of you. Now that the true Substitute has died once for all, what goes on the altar? *You do: alive.* The symbol has finally given way to the reality it always pointed toward.

Romans 12:1 (third click). "Present your bodies as a sacrifice: *alive*, holy, and pleasing to God." *Alive* is the shocking word: a living sacrifice is almost a contradiction in terms, and Paul means the tension. Recall Week 2's NET study note: the trouble with living sacrifices is that they keep

crawling off the altar. A dead sacrifice can't renegotiate; a living one can, and constantly wants to, which is exactly why the offering has to be renewed daily (the payoff comes in segment 4).

The three named sacrifices (fourth click). The New Testament names what we actually offer, and they're concrete enough to *do* this week: **praise**: "a sacrifice of praise… the fruit of lips that confess his name" (Heb 13:15); **good done and possessions shared**: "with such sacrifices God is pleased" (Heb 13:16); and **the self entire**: "a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices" (1 Pet 2:5). Worship, generosity, a life. Nothing abstract.

Transition: "And notice what Peter just called you: a *priest*."

Segment 3: You Are the Priest (20:00–32:00 · Slide 4)

1 Peter 2:5, 9 (first click). "You are a royal priesthood… a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ." The priesthood of *all* believers, not clergy alone. Everyone in the room is a priest with an offering to bring. There is no spectator class in New Covenant worship.

The transfer (second click): the convicting pivot of the week. Feel its weight: the book of Malachi's rebuke was addressed *to priests*, about the *quality* of what they brought to the altar. Peter has just made *you* the priest. Which means Malachi's complaint now arrives at your door **with no middleman**: no professional standing between you and the standard, no "the ministers handle worship" to hide behind.

Malachi 1:8 (third click). "When you present blind animals for sacrifice, is that not wrong?… Try presenting them to your governor! Would he be pleased with you?" Deliver "offer it to your governor!" as the dry, pointed sarcasm it is; the verse is already sharp, so don't raise your voice; let it cut on its own. The image is devastating in its ordinariness: you would never hand your employer, your commanding officer, the shoddy leftover you routinely hand God. The blind, the lame, the leftover: brought precisely *because* it cost nothing.

2 Samuel 24:24 (fourth click). The standard that crossed every covenant untouched: the best, the whole, the unblemished, stated by David in twelve words that are the whole doctrine of cost: "I will not offer to the LORD my God burnt sacrifices that cost me nothing." If the class remembers one sentence from this week, make it this one. A sacrifice that costs nothing *sacrifices* nothing. It sets up discussion Q1 directly.

Transition: "So the offering is now yourself. But Paul actually said *two* things go on the altar."

Segment 4: Body AND Mind (32:00–45:00 · Slide 5)

This segment is the intellectual summit of the whole course: where four units converge. Give it full weight even though it's late.

Romans 12:1–2 as one unit (first click). Read both verses together; most people stop at verse 1 and miss the payoff. Verse 1: present your *bodies.* Verse 2: "be transformed by the renewing of your *mind*,

so that you may test and approve what is the will of God: what is good and well-pleasing and perfect." Body *and* mind, both on the altar.

The why of the renewed mind (second click). Look at the *purpose clause*: the mind is renewed "so that you may test and approve… what is *good*." The renewal has an aim, and the aim is discernment of the Good.

The convergence (third click): let this land slowly, it's the peak. That purpose clause is *Hebrews 5:14 in Paul's handwriting*. The renewed mind exists to discern the Good: the exact faculty the entire course has been training since Week 1 (the Good as God's character), through Week 5 (the Berean eye, "trained by practice"). **The living sacrifice and trained discernment are not two subjects. They are verses one and two of the same paragraph.** Sacrifice (Units I, III) and discernment (Unit II) were the same thing all along. Invite the class to open Romans 12 and *see* it: this is checkable, not asserted, and seeing it themselves is the point.

The reframe (fourth click). Therefore: daily renewal in the Word is *not preparation for* your sacrifice. It *is* your sacrifice: the daily portion of it. The mind laid on the altar every morning is the offering itself, not the warm-up. This dignifies the ordinary morning chapter (the thing that can feel like a duty or a box to check) as an actual altar act, the living sacrifice being renewed before it crawls off.

The banner (fifth click): "Mercy first, altar second: a thank offering, not a payment." The grace guardrail one final time. Romans 12:1 opens "by the mercies of God": the *therefore* rests on eleven chapters of grace. What we lay down is gratitude for a gift, never a bid to earn one. To discussion.

Segments 5–6: Discussion and Close (45:00–57:00 · Slides 6–7)

Q1: "If your time this week were an animal brought to Malachi's altar, what condition would it be in?" The Malachi image made personal and searching. Most of us give God the exhausted, distracted, leftover minutes: the blind and lame of our time. **Model it first-person** ("I've brought that lamb") so it lands as confession, not accusation, and **do not let it curdle into guilt**; the frame is grace. Turn it constructive: what would a *firstfruits* offering of time actually look like? Concrete, not condemning.

Q2: "What are the 'first minutes' of your day currently given to?" The practical companion. For most people the first minutes go to the phone, the news feed, email, or the day's worries, whatever "gets your mind before God does." Steer away from legalism about a specific clock hour; the principle is *firstfruits versus leftovers* applied to *attention*. Seed if quiet: "What has your mind before God does?" The honest answers are usually convicting on their own; you don't need to press.

The close (slide 7, ~2 min). Unit III ends; Unit IV (God's House) begins next week; it's *contested* ground, so signal it kindly. Reading: 1 Corinthians 14:26–40 (what governs public worship; note v.37's "the Lord's command") and Jude 3 ("the faith once for all *entrusted*": where authority comes from). Both flagged. Give the class a heads-up: the next two weeks handle genuinely disputed questions about church order, and we'll do it exactly as Bereans: eager *and* examining,

testing even the teacher (Week 5's permission). Carry sentence: say it together. Close on 2 Samuel 24:24. Dismiss on time.

Answers to Questions You May Get

"If Christ's sacrifice was 'once for all,' aren't we adding to it by offering our own (as the Mass is accused of doing)?" No, and this is the week's most important clarification, so make it crisp. There are two entirely different *kinds* of sacrifice in view. Christ's was **propitiatory** (it atoned, paid for sin, and satisfied justice), and Hebrews insists it is finished, unrepeatable, complete (10:10, 14). Ours are **eucharistic/responsive** (praise, generosity, and a surrendered life), offered *because* atonement is finished, as worship and thanks, never to atone. We don't add to the cross; we respond to it. The living sacrifice of Romans 12 begins with "*therefore*, by the mercies of God," the reply to a finished gift, not a supplement to it.

"Does 'present your bodies' mean asceticism: punishing the body, extreme fasting, that kind of thing?" No. "Bodies" in Paul means the whole embodied self: your hands, your schedule, your appetites, your actual life in the world, offered to God's use, not harmed. Romans 6 already framed it: present your "members" as instruments of righteousness. And verse 2's balance is "renewing of the *mind*": this is comprehensive devotion, not bodily abuse. Colossians 2:23 explicitly warns that "severe treatment of the body" has an appearance of wisdom but no real value against the flesh. The living sacrifice is a life *used* for God, not a body *mortified* to impress him.

"Doesn't the priesthood of all believers make pastors and elders unnecessary?" No, the New Testament holds both at once without contradiction. Every believer is a priest with direct access to God and an offering to bring (1 Pet 2:5); *and* God appoints elders, overseers, and teachers to shepherd and equip the body (Eph 4:11–12; 1 Tim 3; Titus 1). Universal priesthood abolishes the idea of a *mediating* class that stands between you and God; Christ is the only mediator (1 Tim 2:5). It does not abolish *leadership* and *order*. That distinction is exactly what next week (apostolic appointment) unpacks, so flag it forward.

"How can a sacrifice be 'living'? Isn't the whole idea of sacrifice that something dies?" Paul intends the paradox. Under the old covenant, yes, the animal died. The genius of Romans 12:1 is that because Christ has died *in our place*, we don't die on the altar; we live on it, dying to self-rule while remaining alive to serve (Gal 2:20, "I have been crucified with Christ, and it is no longer I who live"). The "death" is the daily surrender of our own will; the "life" is everything that surrendered life is now freed to do. It's harder than a one-time death, actually: the NET note's joke is that living sacrifices keep crawling off the altar, which is why the offering is *daily*.

"Is God really displeased with tired, distracted worship? Sometimes leftovers are all I've got." Careful, grace-filled answer here, because a weary single parent or a sick member may hear condemnation where none is meant. Malachi's rebuke is aimed at people bringing the blind and lame *while keeping the good for themselves* (Mal 1:14): deliberate, calculated stinginess, not the honest exhaustion of someone giving God their real, limited best. The widow's two coins were "leftovers" by any external measure, and Jesus said she gave more than all the rich (Mark 12:43–

44), *because* it cost her everything she had. God measures the *cost to you*, not the size of the gift. The tired parent who turns to God in genuine weariness is bringing the best of a hard day; that's the widow's mite, not Malachi's blemished lamb. The question isn't "is it impressive?" but "is it honest, and is it my real first, or my calculated leftover?"

Prep Checklist

- [ ] Read Hebrews 10:1–18 whole: the standing/seated priest contrast needs its context
- [ ] Read Romans 12:1–2 in at least two translations; be ready to walk the purpose clause of v.2 slowly
- [ ] Read Malachi 1:6–14 entire: the "keep the good, offer the blind" motive (1:14) is your answer to the "tired worship" question
- [ ] Reread Week 5's material so the Hebrews 5:14 convergence lands as a genuine callback, not a new claim
- [ ] Decide your first-person "I've brought that lamb" confession for discussion Q1
- [ ] Prepare the propitiatory-vs-eucharistic distinction in plain words (it's the top question)
- [ ] Print/post next week's reading with both flags, and plan how you'll preview the "contested ground" of Unit IV kindly

If You Run Long

Cut in this order: compress the Heb 10:11–12 standing/seated contrast on slide 2 to one sentence (keep "once for all"); trim the three named sacrifices on slide 3 to two (keep praise and the self); shorten the Malachi 1:8 unpacking on slide 4 (the verse carries itself). **Never cut:** the once-for-all guard (segment 1 in some form: it's the atonement guardrail), the "changed material" hinge on slide 3, the Romans 12 = Hebrews 5:14 convergence on slide 5 (the course's intellectual peak), or the mercy-first banner. If discussion must shrink, keep Q1: the Malachi-altar-of-time image is the week's most tangible, memorable application, and it sends people home examining something concrete.